

A QUESTION OF EXPERIENCE? “RACE”, AND SOCIAL THEORY.

Part 1

The word “race”

- ▣ This word is similar to the French word “racine” which means root
- ▣ It is possible that it is related to the Arabic word “ras” which means “head” or “beginning”.
- ▣ It was only in the 19th century that it was incorporated into biology and seemed to refer to a particular biological group or type or category.
- ▣ “Racism”, strictly speaking, means the belief that there are real, fixed, differences in terms of character, intelligence or morals between different “types” of humans.

Some Questions...

- ▣ Who believes that there are different races of people within the general human race?
- ▣ How many races are there?
- ▣ Name them....
- ▣ If there are different races, then do they have different characteristics? How can you tell?
- ▣ What criteria or “facts” would you use to identify different races?

Think about those people who want to “know” where someone is “really” from....

"Where are you really from?"

The Origins of Scientific Racism (1)

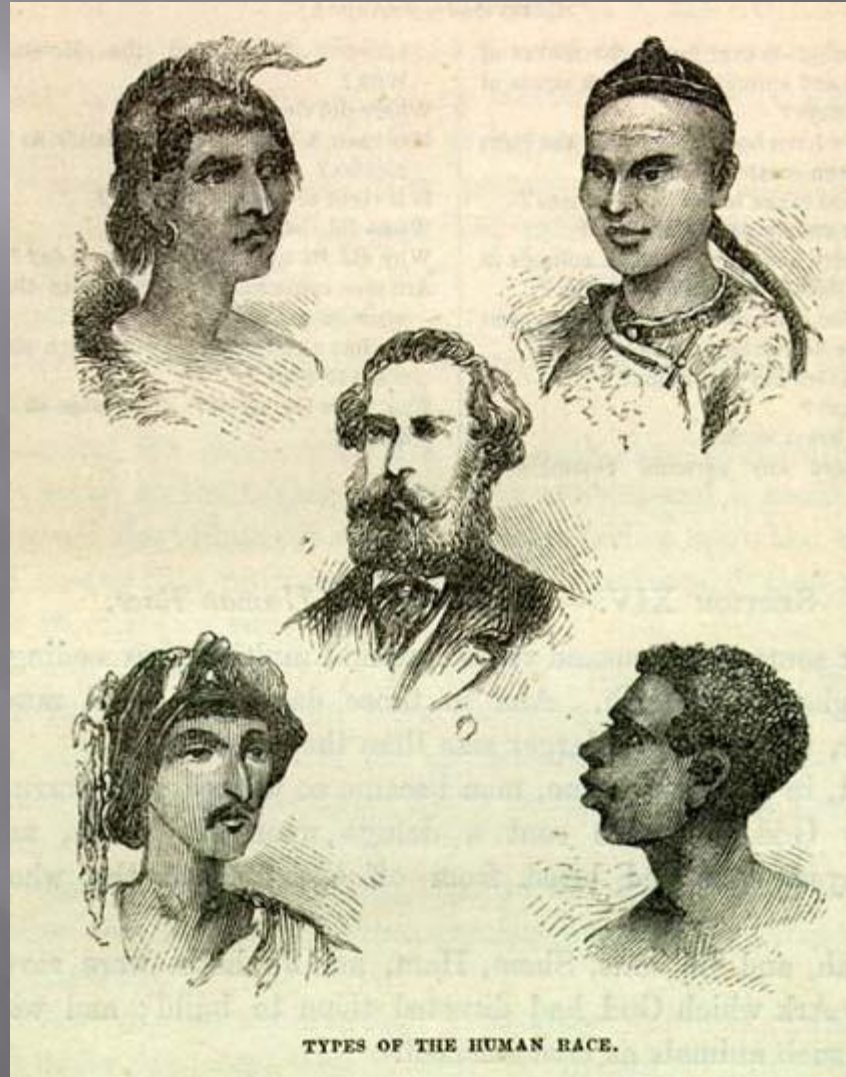
- ▣ Linnaeus who invented the system of classification of all plants and animal into classes, species, gener, etc. divided *Homo Sapiens* into four major races (subspecies) in his *Systema Naturae* (1735):
 - ▣ *Homo Europaeus* (Europeans)
 - ▣ *Homo Afer* (Sub-Saharan Africans)
 - ▣ *Homo Asiaticus* (Asians)
 - ▣ *Homo Americanus* (Native Americans).
- ▣ These classification was based on both morphological features and maintained *that they also showed differences in temperament and psychology.*
- ▣ (Northern Europeans)
- ▣ (Southern Europeans).

The Origins of Scientific Racism (2)

- ▣ Johann Friedrich Blumenbach (1752-1840) believed that there were 5 races. It was claimed that evidence for this could be found in the different structures of their skulls.
- ▣ The Caucasian (white race)
- ▣ The Mongolian (yellow race)
- ▣ The Malayan (brown race)
- ▣ The Negroid (black race)
- ▣ The American (red race)
- ▣ Again, the idea is that what can be supposedly known is not just physical differences, but psychological differences (differences in temperament)



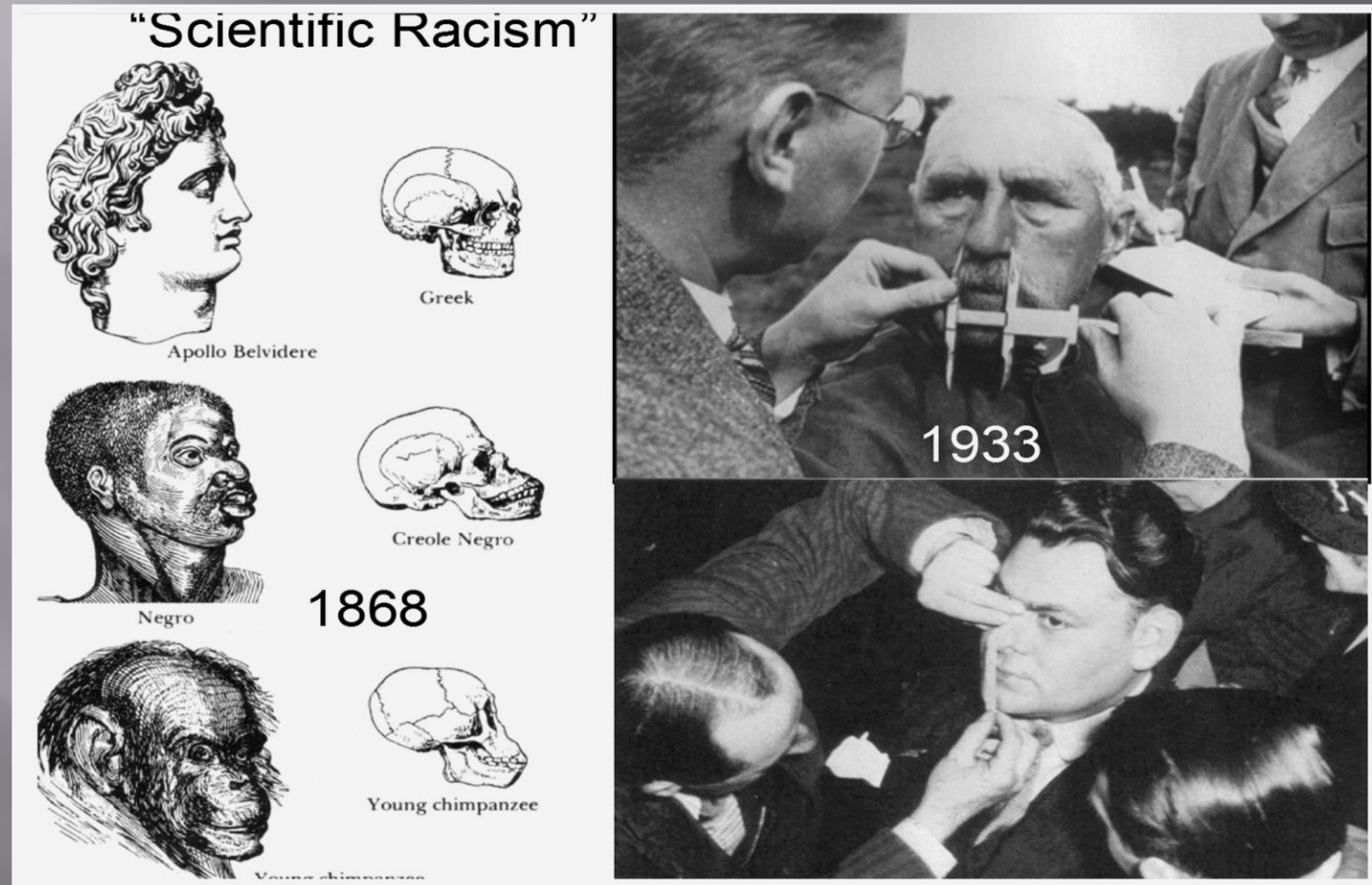
Scientific Racism



Scientific Racism – Power/knowledge

- ▣ Science claimed to “observe” racial differences
- ▣ The classifications they produced appeared to give them knowledge (of different kinds of humans)
- ▣ This was tied up with specific power relations (to do with “race”)
- ▣ This **power-knowledge** “produced” ways of viewing people which still have effects today
- ▣ Remember Foucault from last week.
- ▣ Is this one reason why the question of “colour” runs throughout discussions of “race”, as there needs to be something to be “observed” in order to classify?
- ▣ This is tied to questions of vision and power.

Scientific Racism (and questions of “inferiority”)



Du Bois on “Race” and “Colour”

- ▣ ‘the difference in skin color was vastly overemphasized and intrinsically trivial. And yet this fact of racial distinction based on color was the greatest thing in my life and absolutely determined it’ Du Bois, 1968. *Dusk of Dawn*: 136
- ▣ The following quotation is from a “fictional” dialogue that Du Bois sets out between him and a white person of his time.
- ▣ ‘Race is a cultural, sometimes a historical fact. And all that I really have been trying to say is that a certain group that I know and to which I belong, as contrasted with the group you know and to which you belong, and in which you fanatically and glorifyingly believe, bears in its bosom just now the spiritual hope of this land because of the persons who compose it and not by divine command.
- ▣ “But what is this group: and how do you differentiate it; and how can you call it “black” when you admit it is not black?”
- ▣ I recognize it quite easily and with full legal sanction; the black man is a person who must ride “Jim Crow” in Georgia.’ Du Bois, 1968. *Dusk of Dawn* p. 153

Part 2

W. E. B. Du Bois



- ▣ Born in Massachusetts in 1868. Died in 1963.
- ▣ A short video:
 - ▣ <http://www.biography.com/people/we-b-du-bois-9279924/videos>
- ▣ In the 1890s, he studied for a while in Germany (Berlin)
- ▣ The first black person to get a PhD from Harvard.
- ▣ A polymath - a true intellectual
- ▣ He was living in the first generation of African Americans after they had been “emancipated” from slavery in 1863.

Some Context

- ▣ In 1863, during the American Civil War, Abraham Lincoln declared in the “Emancipation Proclamation” that all slaves were free, forever.
- ▣ By the end of the 1860s, the US Constitution was amended and stated that it was not possible to deny someone the vote based on their “race” or “color” [sic] or because they had been slaves.
- ▣ Writing a generation after all this, in the 1890s, Du Bois asked why nothing had really changed for African Americans. He sought to investigate.

Some Details (All quotations are in the Key Reading for this week from *The Souls of Black Folk*)

- ▣ 'being a problem is a strange experience' (4)
- ▣ Du Bois tells of an incident from his childhood. He was playing with school friends when they decided to exchange "visiting cards".
- ▣ One girl refused to accept his.
- ▣ Why?
- ▣ So, he says...

- ▣ 'it dawned on me with a certain suddenness that I was different from the others...shut out from their world by a vast veil' (4)
- ▣ Gibson comments on this passage as follows:
- ▣ 'one's sense of race and racial terms comes only from experience, the meaning of being black or white is not inborn but is derived from experience.' (Gibson, 1996: xxv – from his 'Introduction' to Du Bois, 1996 [1903]. *The Souls of Black Folk*. London. Penguin)

Du Bois says that the veil which separates him from the other world constitutes his experience of reality...

- ▣ This leads to one of Du Bois' most important concepts – that of “double consciousness”
- ▣ ‘It is a peculiar sensation, this double-consciousness, this sense of always looking at one's self through the eyes of others, of measuring one's soul by the tape of a world that looks on in amused contempt and pity.’ (5)
- ▣ ‘a world which yields him [the Negro] no true self-consciousness but only lets him see himself through the revelation of the other world.’ (5)

Double-Consciousness is different to the versions of consciousness of Weber, Goffman, Garfinkel...

- ▣ For, Du Bois states that being double is the basis of the experience of the world. This differs from the sense of unity, of being a single actor, which is presumed by Weber, Goffman, Garkinkel.
- ▣ 'One ever feels his twoness, - an American, a Negro; two souls, two thoughts, two unreconciled strivings' (5)
- ▣ 'The history of the American Negro is the history of this strife – this longing to attain self-conscious manhood, to merge his double self into a better and truer self.' (5)

To read later...

- ▣ 'This waste of double aims, this seeking to satisfy two unreconciled ideals, has wrought sad havoc with the courage and faith and deeds of ten thousand thousand people, - has sent them often wooing false gods and invoking false means of salvation, and at times has even seemed about to make them ashamed of themselves.' (6)

(Only if time...) Equality in law is not enough.

- ▣ Despite the Emancipation Proclamation of 1863 and the “right to vote” of the 15th amendment to the Constitution –
- ▣ ‘The Nation has not yet found peace from its sins; the freedman has not yet found freedom in his promised land.’ (7)
- ▣ Why not?
- ▣ ‘Work, culture, liberty, - all these we need, not singly but together’ (11)

(Only if time...) What is to be done?

- ▣ '...he wishes neither of the older selves to be lost. He would not Africanize America, for America has much to teach the world...
- ▣ He simply wishes to make it possible for a man to be both a Negro and an American' (5)
- ▣ This is not as easy as it might sound.
- ▣ And this is partly because of the link of modernity and slavery (which we have talked about before)
- ▣ For example:....

Du Bois, Slavery, History and Modernity

- ▣ 'In the latter part of the seventeenth and early in the eighteenth centuries, the central and all-absorbing economic need of America was the creation of a proper labor supply to develop American wealth. This question had been answered in the West Indies by enslaving Indians and Negroes. In the colonies of the mainland it was answered by the importation of Negroes and indentured servants. Immediately then there arose the question of the legal status of these slaves and servants; and dozens of enactments, from Massachusetts to Georgia, were made "for the proper regulation of slaves and servants". Such statutes sought to solve problems of labor and not of race or color. Two circumstances, however, soon began to differentiate in the problem of labor, problems which concerned slaves for life from those which concerned servants for limited periods; and these circumstances were the economic superiority of the slave system, and the fact that the slaves were neither of the same race, language nor religion as the servants and their masters. In laboring classes thus widely separated there naturally arose a difference in legal and social standing. Colonial statutes soon ceased to embrace the regulations applying to slaves and servants in one chapter, and laws were passed for servants on the one hand and for Negro slaves on the other' Du Bois, 1898: 3-4
- ▣ Du Bois, W.E.B. 1898. "The Study of the Negro Problems" in *Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* (Jan 1898: 1-23)
- ▣

Part 3

Toni Morrison (1931-2019)



- ▣ Novelist, writer and thinker.
- ▣ Recent book (from a set of lectures she gave at Harvard in 2016):
- ▣ Morrison, T. 2017. *The Origin of Others*, Cambridge, MA, Harvard University Press.

Morrison on “Others” and “Othering”

- ▣ ‘What is race (other than genetic imagination) and why does it matter? Once its parameters are known, defined (if at all possible), what behaviour does it demand/encourage? Race is the classification of a species, and we are the human race, period [full-stop]. Then what is this other thing – the hostility, the social racism, the Othering.’ P. 15
- ▣ She cites Bruce Baum: ‘Race, in short, is an effect of power.’ P. 25
- ▣ ‘The necessity of rendering the slave a foreign species appears to be a desperate attempt to confirm one’s own self as normal.’ P.

More on Morrison (2017)

- ▣ ‘immigrants to the United States understood that if they wanted to become “real” Americans they must sever or at least downplay their ties to their native country, in order to embrace their whiteness. The definition of “Americanness” (sadly) remains color for many people.’ P. 17
- ▣ [Think also about Trump and what it means nowadays to be a “Mexican-American”]
- ▣ ‘routine media presentations deploy images and language that narrow our views of what humans look like (or ought to look like) and what in fact we are like.’ P. 37



Also, see Toni Morrison's novels such as:

- ▣ *Beloved*
- ▣ *Paradise*
- ▣ *The Bluest Eye*

Novels can help us think about the world. If you like, you might want to read:

Octavia Butler's book *Dawn*

(Or for something which links to Foucault and feminism, why not try:
Angela Carter's *The Magic Toyshop*)

Paul Gilroy – Currently at
UCL, University of London,
London.

Previously was at LSE,
Harvard, Goldsmiths and...
Essex!

Most famous books:

‘There Ain’t No Black in the
Union Jack’

‘The Black Atlantic. Modernity
and Double Consciousness.’

‘Between Camps’ which was
published as ‘Against Race’ in
the US.



“Race Ends Here” (this article is one of the key readings on Talis in the *The Body: a Reader*)

- ▣ Gilroy was influenced by Foucault, though he does not completely agree with him.
- ▣ “‘race’” was a primary object of knowledge and power’ (p. 252)

Gilroy argues that race and modernity are inextricably linked.

- ▣ He also says that:
- ▣ Africa was not on the side-lines of the West and the development of modernity
- ▣ The transnational (as evidenced in the slave trade) was always a real part of Western Modernity. Hence the “Black Atlantic.”
- ▣ Ethnic/“Racial” identities are not fixed but are outcomes of wider political, economic, and cultural processes.
- ▣ We need to rethink history and modernity and not just “include” the marginal positions that have been ignored. But to rewrite history and modernity from these positions.

The Black Atlantic

- ▣ 'racial terror is not merely compatible with occidental rationality but cheerfully complicit with it' (Think of Dussel)
- ▣ 'The time has come for the primal history of modernity to be reconstructed from the slaves' point of view'

“Standpoint” (To read later)

- ▣ ‘This unstable standpoint is to be understood in a different way from the clarion calls to...unmediated experience which sometimes appear in association with the term.’
- ▣ ‘In terms of contemporary politics and social theory, the value of this project lies in its promise to uncover both an ethics of freedom to set alongside modernity’s ethics of law and the new conceptions of selfhood...that are waiting to be constructed from the slaves’ standpoint...’ (Think of Du Bois)

Conclusion

- ▣ Races do not exist
- ▣ But the experiences constituted by the belief, practices, history and economics of “race” do.
- ▣ This is not simply about “racism” and individuals being racist.
- ▣ It is about how the modern social world is constituted on forms of racism which we might not be able to recognise immediately but are present in, for example, institutions, art galleries, music, and ways of seeing.